Hegel, Phenomenology of Spirit (trans. Inwood) Oxford 2018
"Master + Slave"

as such, or as *self-consciousness. Self-consciousness achieves its satisfaction only in another self-consciousness.*[1]

¶176. The concept of self-consciousness is only completed in these three moments: (a) the pure undifferentiated I is its first immediate object; (b) but this immediacy is itself an absolute mediation, it is only as a sublation of the independent object, or it is desire. The satisfaction of desire is of course the reflection of self-consciousness into itself, or the certainty that has become truth; and (c) but the truth of this certainty is really a double reflection, the duplication of self-consciousness. There is for consciousness an object which, in its own Self, posits its otherness or posits the difference as a null difference, and in so doing is independent. The differentiated, merely *living*, shape does indeed also sublate its independence in the process of life itself, but it ceases with its difference to be what it is; but the object of self-consciousness is just as independent in this negativity of itself; and thus it is for itself genus, universal fluidity in the peculiarity of its isolation; it is living self-consciousness.[1]

¶177. There is a *self-consciousness for a self-consciousness*. Only so is it in fact self-consciousness; for only in this way does the unity of itself in its otherness come to be for it; *I*, which is the object of its concept, is in fact not *object*; the object of desire, however, is only *independent*, for it is the universal indestructible substance, the fluid essence equal-to-its-own-self. When a self-consciousness is the object, the object is just as much I as object.—With this, we already have before us the concept *of spirit*. What still lies ahead for consciousness is the experience of what spirit is, this absolute substance which, in the perfect freedom and independence of its opposition, viz. of diverse self-consciousnesses that are for themselves, is the unity of these self-consciousnesses: *I* that is *We*, and *We* that is *I*. It is in self-consciousness, as the concept of spirit, that consciousness first has its turning-point, where it leaves behind the colourful semblance of the sensory here-and-now and the empty night of the super-sensible Beyond, and steps out into the spiritual day of presence.[1]

A. Independence and dependence of self-consciousness: lordship and bondage

¶178. Self-consciousness is *in* and *for itself*, when, and by the fact that, it is in and for itself for another self-consciousness; that is, it is only as something recognized. The concept of this its unity in its duplication, of the infinity realizing itself in self-consciousness, is a many-sided and ambiguous interlacing, so that the moments of this unity must on the one hand be kept strictly apart, and on the other hand must in this differentiation at the same time also be taken and cognized as not distinct, or always in their opposite significance. The twofold sense of the distinct moments lies in the essence of self-consciousness, which is to be infinite, or immediately the contrary of the determinacy in which it is posited. The explication of the concept of this spiritual unity in its duplication presents to us the movement of *recognition*.[1]

¶179. There is for self-consciousness another self-consciousness; it has come *out of itself*. This has a twofold significance: *first*, it has lost itself, for it finds itself as an *other* essence; *secondly*, in doing so it has sublated the other, for it does not see the other as an essence either, but in the *other* sees *its own self*.[1]

¶180. It must sublate this *otherness* of itself; this is the sublation of the first double sense, and is therefore itself a second double sense; *first*, it must proceed to sublate *the other* independent essence in order thereby to become certain *of itself* as the essence; *secondly*, in so doing it proceeds to sublate *its own self*, for this other is itself.[1]

¶181. This ambiguous sublation of its ambiguous otherness is equally an ambiguous return *into itself*; for *first*, through the sublation, it receives back its own self, for by sublating *its* otherness it again becomes equal to itself; but *secondly*, it equally gives the other self-consciousness back to it again, for it found itself in the other, it sublates this Being *of itself* in the other, thus lets the other again go free.[1]

¶182. But this movement of self-consciousness in relation to another self-consciousness has in this way been represented as *the doing of one* of the self-consciousnesses; but this doing of the one has itself the double significance of being both *its own doing* and *the doing of the other* as well; for the other is equally independent, closed within itself, and there is nothing in it of which it is not itself the origin. The first self-consciousness does not have the object before it as the object initially is only for desire, but an independent object that is for itself, to which, therefore, it can do nothing for itself, if that object does not do in its own self what the first does to it. Thus the movement is simply the double movement of the two self-consciousnesses. Each sees *the other* do the same as it does; each does itself what it requires of the other, and therefore also does what it does only insofar as the other does the same; one-sided doing would be useless because what is supposed to happen can only come about through both.[1]

¶183. Thus the doing has a double sense not only because it is directed *on itself* as well as *on the other*, but also because it is inseparably the *doing of the* one as well as *of the other*.[1]

¶184. In this movement we see repeated the process which presented itself as a play of forces, but repeated in consciousness. What, in that play, was for us, is here for the extremes themselves. The middle term is self-consciousness which splits into the extremes; and each extreme is this exchanging of its determinacy and absolute transition into the opposite determinacy. But, as consciousness, it does indeed come *outside itself*, yet, in its Being-outside-itself, it is at the same time kept back within itself, *for itself*, and its outside-itself is *for it*. It is for it that it immediately *is*, and *is not*, another consciousness; and equally that this other is for itself only when it sublates itself as a being-for-itself, and is for itself only in the Being-for-itself of the other. Each is to the other the middle term, through which each mediates itself with itself and joins together with itself, and each is to itself, and to the other, an immediate essence that is for itself, which at the same time is for itself only through this mediation. They *recognize* themselves as *mutually recognizing one another*.[1]

¶185. This pure concept of recognition, of the duplicating of self-consciousness in its unity, now has to be considered, to see how its process appears for self-consciousness. At first, the process will present the side of the *inequality* of the two, or the bifurcation of the middle term into the extremes which, as extremes, are opposed to one another, one being only recognized, the other only recognizing.[1]

¶186. Self-consciousness is initially simple Being-for-itself, equal-to-its-own-self through the exclusion *from itself* of everything *else*; its essence and absolute object is, to it, *I*; and in this *immediacy* or in this *Being* of its Being-for-itself, it is a *singleton*.

What is other for it is as an unessential object, marked with the character of the negative. But the other is also a self-consciousness; an individual comes face to face with an individual. Entering the scene *immediately* in this way, they are for one another in the manner of ordinary objects; *independent* shapes, consciousnesses submerged in the *Being* of *life*—for here the object that is determines itself as life—, consciousnesses that have not yet accomplished *for each other* the movement of absolute abstraction, of eradicating all immediate Being, and of being merely the purely negative Being of consciousness equal-to-itself, or have not as yet presented themselves to each other as pure *Being-for-itself*, that is, as *self*-consciousnesses. Each is indeed certain of its own self, but not of the other, and therefore its own certainty of itself still has no truth; for its truth would be only that its own Being-for-itself had presented itself to it as an independent object, or, what is the same thing, that the object had presented itself as this pure certainty of itself. But according to the concept of recognition this is not possible, unless each of these objects accomplishes this pure abstraction of Being-for-itself, the one for the other, just as the other for the one, each in itself by its own doing and again by the doing of the other.[1]

¶187. But the *presentation* of itself as the pure abstraction of self-consciousness consists in showing itself as the pure negation of its objective mode, or in showing that it is not attached to any determinate *Being-there*, not to the universal singularity of Being-there in general, not attached to life. This presentation is the *twofold* doing: doing of the other, and doing through its own self. Insofar as it is the doing *of the other*, so each aims at the death of the other. But in this the second doing is also present, *the doing through its own self*; for the former involves the staking of its own life. Thus the relationship of the two self-consciousnesses is determined in such a way that they *prove* themselves and each other through a life-and-death combat.—They must engage in this combat, for they must elevate their certainty of themselves, certainty *of being for themselves*, to the truth, in the other and in themselves. And it is only through staking one's life that freedom is established, that it is proved that to self-consciousness the essence is not *Being*, not the *immediate* mode in which it comes on the scene, not its submergence in the expansion of life,—but rather that there is nothing present in it which would not be a vanishing moment for it, that it is only pure *Being-for-itself*. The individual who has not risked his life may well be recognized as a *person*; but it has not attained to the truth of this recognition as recognition of an independent self-consciousness. Similarly, as each stakes its life, so each must aim at the other's death; for it values the other no more than itself; its essence presents itself to it as an other, it is outside itself and must sublate its Being-outside-itself; the other is a manifoldly entangled consciousness that simply is; it must intuit its otherness as pure Being-for-itself or as absolute negation.[1]

¶188. However, this trial by death sublates the truth which was supposed to issue from it, just as it thereby also sublates the certainty of itself in general; for as life is the *natural* position of consciousness, independence without absolute negativity, so death is the *natural* negation of consciousness, negation without independence, which thus remains without the required significance of recognition. Death has indeed given rise to the certainty that both of them staked their life and scorned it, in themselves and in the other; but not for those who endured this combat. They sublate their consciousness posited in this alien essentiality, which is natural

Being-there, or they sublate themselves, and are sublated as *extremes* wanting to be for themselves. But with this there vanishes from the play of exchange the essential moment, that of decomposing into extremes with opposite determinacies; and the middle term collapses into a dead unity which is decomposed into dead, unopposed extremes that simply are; and the two do not reciprocally give and receive themselves back from each other through consciousness, but leave each other free only indifferently, as things. Their deed is abstract negation, not the negation of consciousness, which *sublates* in such a way as to *preserve* and *maintain* what is sublated, and thereby survives its being sublated.[1]

¶189. In this experience, it dawns on self-consciousness that life is as essential to it as pure self-consciousness. In immediate self-consciousness the simple I is the absolute object, which, however, is for us or in itself the absolute mediation and has as its essential moment subsistent independence. The dissolution of that simple unity is the result of the first experience; through this there is posited a pure self-consciousness, and a consciousness which is not purely for itself but for another, i.e. is as consciousness that *is*, or consciousness in the shape of *thinghood*. The two moments are essential;—since initially they are unequal and opposed, and their reflection into unity has not yet ensued, they are as two opposed shapes of consciousness; one is the independent consciousness for which the essence is Being-for-itself, the other is the dependent consciousness for which the essence is life or Being for another; the former is the *lord*, the latter is the *bondsman*.[1]

¶190. The lord is the consciousness that is *for itself*, no longer merely the concept of such a consciousness. Rather, it is a consciousness that is for itself, which is mediated with itself through *another* consciousness, namely, through a consciousness to whose essence it belongs to be synthesized with independent *Being* or thinghood in general. The lord gets into relation with these two moments, to a *thing* as such, the object of desire, and to the consciousness for which thinghood is what is essential; and since he is (a) as concept of self-consciousness, immediate relation of *Being-for-itself*, but (b) from now on, at the same time, as mediation, or as a Being-for-itself which is for itself only through another, he is related (a) immediately to both, and (b) mediately to each through the other. The lord relates himself mediately *to the bondsman through independent Being*, for it is just this which holds the bondsman; it is his chain from which he could not abstract in the combat, thus proving to be dependent, to have his independence in thinghood. But the lord is the power over this Being, for he proved in the combat that it counts for him only as something negative; since he is the power over this, while this Being is the power over the other, in this syllogism he thus has the other under him. Equally, the lord relates himself *mediately to the thing through the bondsman*; the bondsman, as self-consciousness in general, also relates himself negatively to the thing, and sublates it; but at the same time the thing is independent for the bondsman, and he therefore cannot through his negating have done with it to the point of annihilation, or he only *works on* it. For the lord, by contrast, there *comes about* through this mediation the *immediate* relation as the sheer negation of the thing, or *enjoyment*; he succeeds in doing, what desire failed to do: in having done with it, and satisfying himself in enjoyment. Desire failed in this because of the thing's independence; but the lord, who has interposed the bondsman between it and himself, thereby joins together

only with the dependence of the thing and enjoys it purely; as for the side of independence he leaves that to the bondsman, who works on the thing.[1]

¶191. In these two moments recognition comes about for the lord through another consciousness; for this other consciousness posits itself in these moments as something unessential, first in working on the thing, and secondly in dependency on a determinate Being-there; in neither moment can it become master over Being and attain to absolute negation. Thus there is present here this moment of recognition, in which the other consciousness sublates itself as Being-for-itself, and thereby itself does what the first does to it. Likewise the other moment, that this doing of the second is the first's own doing; for what the bondsman does is really the doing of the lord; to the lord alone belongs Being-for-itself, the essence; he is the pure negative power for which the thing is nothing, and thus the pure, essential doing in this relationship; to the bondsman belongs a doing that is not pure, but unessential. But for recognition proper the moment is lacking, that what the lord does to the other he should also do to himself, and what the bondsman does to himself he should also do to the other. What has thereby arisen is a recognition that is one-sided and unequal.[1]

¶192. In this, the unessential consciousness is for the lord the object, which constitutes the *truth* of certainty of himself. But it is clear that this object does not correspond to its concept, but rather that there, where the lord has fulfilled himself, he finds something quite other than an independent consciousness. What is for him is not an independent consciousness, but a dependent one; therefore, he is not certain of *Being-for-itself* as the truth, but his truth is rather the unessential consciousness and its unessential doing.[1]

¶193. The *truth* of the independent consciousness is accordingly the *servile consciousness*. This servile consciousness does indeed appear initially *outside* of itself and not as the truth of self-consciousness. But just as lordship showed that its essence is the inverse of what it wants to be, so too servitude in its consummation will really turn into the contrary of what it immediately is; as a consciousness *driven back* into itself, it will withdraw into itself and be converted into true independence.[1]

¶194. We have seen what servitude is only in relationship to lordship. But it is self-consciousness, and accordingly we have now to consider what it is in and for itself. Initially, for servitude the lord is the essence; hence the *independent consciousness that is for itself* is its *truth*, a truth, however, that *for it* is not yet *within it*. But it does *in fact* have *within itself* this truth of pure negativity and *Being-for-itself*, for it has *experienced* this essence within it. That is to say, this consciousness has had anxiety, not about this or that and not just at odd moments, but anxiety for its whole essence; for it has felt the fear of death, of the absolute lord. In this it has been internally dissolved, has trembled through and through within itself, and everything fixed has quaked in it. But this pure universal movement, the absolute liquidization of all subsistence, is the simple essence of self-consciousness, absolute negativity, *pure Being-for-itself*, which is thus *within* this consciousness. This moment of pure Being-for-itself is also *for it*, for in the lord this moment is its *object*. Furthermore, this consciousness is not only this universal dissolution *in general*, but in its service it accomplishes it *actually*; in serving it sublates its attachment to natural Being-there in all *singular* moments; and gets rid of this Being-there by working on it.[1]

¶195. However, the feeling of absolute power in general, and in the singularity of service, is only dissolution *in itself*, and although the fear of the lord is indeed the beginning of wisdom, in this the consciousness is *for it itself*, not *Being-for-itself*. Through work, however, it comes to its own self. In the moment which corresponds to desire in the lord's consciousness, the side of unessential relation to the thing did seem to have fallen to the lot of the serving consciousness, since in that relation the thing retains its independence. Desire has reserved to itself the pure negating of the object and thereby unalloyed self-feeling. But for that reason this satisfaction is itself only a disappearance, for it lacks the *objective* side or *subsistence*. Work, by contrast, is desire *held in check*, fleetingness *staved off*, or work *cultivates*. The negative relation to the object becomes its *form* and something *permanent*, because it is precisely for the worker that the object has independence. This *negative* middle term or the formative *doing* is at the same time *the singularity* or the pure Being-for-itself of consciousness, which now, in working, steps outside itself into the element of permanence; in this way, therefore, the working consciousness arrives at the intuition of independent Being *as of its own self*.[1]

¶196. However, the forming does not only have this positive significance that in it the serving consciousness, as pure Being-for-itself, becomes a *being* in its own eyes; the forming also has a negative significance in the face of its first moment, fear. For, in cultivating the thing, the serving consciousness's own negativity, its Being-for-itself, becomes an object for it only through its sublating the being, the *form*, opposed to it. But this objective *negative* is just the alien essence before which it has trembled. Now, however, it destroys this alien negative, posits *itself* as such a negative in the element of permanence, and thereby becomes *for itself* a *being-for-itself*. In the lord, the Being-for-itself is *an other* to it, or only *for it*; in fear, the Being-for-itself is *within it itself*; in its cultivating, the Being-for-itself becomes for it as *its own* Being-for-itself, and it arrives at the consciousness that it itself is in and for itself. The form is *posited outside*, but is not regarded as thereby becoming something other than serving consciousness; for it is precisely this form that is its pure Being-for-itself, which in this externality is seen by it to be the truth. Through this rediscovery of itself by itself, the serving consciousness realizes that it is precisely in its labour, wherein it seemed to have only an *alienated mind*, that it acquires a *mind of its own*.—For this reflection, the two moments of fear and of service in general, as also that of cultivating, are necessary, and both at the same time in a universal mode. Without the discipline of service and obedience, fear remains a formality and does not extend to the conscious actuality of Being-there. Without the cultivating, fear remains inward and mute, and consciousness does not become for it itself. If consciousness forms the thing without that initial absolute fear, it is only a vain mind of its own; for its form or negativity is not negativity *in itself*; and therefore its forming cannot give it the consciousness of itself as the essence. If it has not endured absolute fear but only some anxiety, the negative essence has remained for it something external, its substance has not been infected by it through and through. Since not all acquisitions of its natural consciousness have been shaken, it still belongs *in itself* to determinate Being; a mind of one's own is *self-will*, a freedom that is still enmeshed in servitude. As little as the pure form can become the essence for it, just as little is that form, regarded as expansion over the singular, a universal forming, an absolute

concept; rather it is a skill that is master over a few things, but not over the universal power and the whole objective essence.[1]

B. *Freedom of self-consciousness: stoicism, scepticism, and the unhappy consciousness*

¶197. For the independent self-consciousness, on the one hand its essence is only the pure abstraction of *the I*, and on the other hand, when this abstraction develops and acquires differences, this differentiation does not become an objective essence that is *in itself*; so this self-consciousness does not become an I that in its simplicity is genuinely self-differentiating, or that in this absolute differentiation remains identical with itself. By contrast, the consciousness that is driven back into itself becomes, in the act of forming, its own object as form of the thing it has cultivated, and in the lord it intuits at the same time Being-for-itself as consciousness. But for the subservient consciousness as such, these two moments—that of *itself* as independent object, and that of this object as a consciousness, and hence its own essence—fall apart. Since, however, the *form* and the *Being-for-itself* are *for us*, or *in themselves*, the same, and since in the concept of the independent consciousness the Being-*in-itself* is consciousness, the side of Being-*in-itself* or *thinghood*, which received the form in the labour, is no other substance than consciousness, and a new shape of self-consciousness has arisen for us; a consciousness which, as the infinitude or the pure movement of consciousness, is aware of itself as the essence; a consciousness that *thinks* or is free self-consciousness. For to *think* means to be one's own object not as *abstract I*, but as an I that has at the same time the significance of Being-*in-itself*, of having itself for object, or of relating itself to the objective essence in such a way that it has the significance of the *Being-for-itself* of the consciousness for which it is.—For *thinking*, the object does not move in representations or shapes, but in *concepts*, i.e. in a distinct Being-in-itself, which immediately, for consciousness, is not at all distinct from it. What is *represented*, *shaped*, a *being*, has, as such, the form of being something other than consciousness; but a concept is at the same time a *being*, and this difference, insofar as it is in the concept itself, is its determinate content,—but since this content is at the same time a content conceptualized, consciousness remains *immediately* conscious of its unity with this determinate and differentiated being, not, as in the case of representation, where consciousness still has specifically to remind itself that this is *its* representation; whereas the concept is for me immediately *my* concept. In thinking, I *am free*, because I am not in an other, but remain simply together with myself, and the object, which is for me the essence, is in undivided unity my Being-for-myself; and my movement in concepts is a movement within myself.—But in this determination of this shape of self-consciousness it is essential to keep in mind that this shape is *thinking* consciousness *in general*, or its object is *immediate* unity of *Being-in-itself* and *Being-for-itself*. The consciousness homonymous with itself that repels itself from itself becomes to itself an *element that is in-itself*; but at first it is to itself this element only as universal essence in general, not as this objective essence in the development and movement of its manifold Being.[1]

¶198. This freedom of self-consciousness, when it emerged as its conscious appearance in the history of spirit, was, as we know, called *Stoicism*. Its principle is that consciousness is thinking essence, and that something has essentiality for consciousness, or is true and good for it, only as consciousness comports itself therein as thinking essence.[1]

¶199. The manifold expansion of life, differentiating itself within itself, the singularization and complication of life, is the object on which desire and labour are active. This manifold doing has now contracted into the simple differentiating which occurs in the pure movement of thinking. What has more essentiality is not the difference that presents itself as *determinate thing*, or as *consciousness of a determinate natural Being-there*, as a feeling, or as *desire* and *purpose for this desire*, whether this purpose is set by one's *own* consciousness or by *an alien consciousness*, but only the difference that is a *thought* difference, or is immediately not distinct from me. This consciousness is consequently negative towards the relationship of lordship and bondage; its doing is, in lordship, not to have its truth in the bondsman, nor, as bondsman, to have its truth in the will of the lord and in his service, but to be free, whether on the throne or in chains, in all the dependency of its singular Being-there, and to maintain for itself the lifelessness that constantly *withdraws* from the movement of Being-there, from activity as well as from suffering, into *the simple essentiality of thought*. Self-will is the freedom that fastens onto a singularity and stands *within* bondage, while Stoicism is the freedom that always comes immediately out of bondage and back into the *pure universality* of thought. As universal form of the world-spirit, Stoicism could only emerge in a time of universal fear and bondage, but also in the time of a universal culture that had elevated cultivation up to thinking.[1]

¶200. Now, it is true that for this self-consciousness the essence is neither an other than itself, nor the pure abstraction of the I; the essence is I, which has otherness in it, but as a difference in thought, so that in its otherness the I has immediately returned into itself. Yet at the same time this essence of self-consciousness is only an *abstract* essence. The freedom of self-consciousness is *indifferent* to natural Being-there, has therefore *likewise let this Being-there go free*, and the *reflection* is a *double* reflection. Freedom in thought has only *pure thought* as its truth, a truth without the fullness of life; and so it is also only the concept of freedom, not living freedom itself; for the essence of that freedom is at first only *thinking* in general, the form as such, which has turned away from the independence of things and returned into itself. But since the singularity, as acting, should present itself as full of life or, as thinking, should grasp the living world as a system of thought, there would have to reside *in thought itself* a *content*, for the expansion of action a content of what is good, for the expansion of thinking a content of what is true, in order that in *what is for consciousness* there should be no other ingredient *whatsoever* except the concept which is the essence. But here the concept as *abstraction* cuts itself off from the multiplicity of things, and so it has *no content in itself* but a content *given to it*. Consciousness does indeed eliminate the content as an alien Being, when it thinks it; but the concept is a *determinate* concept, and this *determinacy* of the concept is the alien element that it has in it. Stoicism therefore got into difficulties when it was asked, as they expressed it, for the *criterion* of truth in general, i.e. strictly speaking, for a *content* of *thought itself*. To the question put to it, *what* is good and true, it again gave in answer the